

From Challenge to Consensus:

Pathways for Inclusive Growth in Africa

White Paper

Ephias Ruhode
Kingsley Obi Omeihe

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From Challenge to Consensus: Pathways for *Inclusive Growth* in Africa

In this white paper, Ephias Ruhode and Kingsley O. Omeihe reflect on the conversations and debates that emerged at the inaugural Atlas Global Academic Conference in Victoria Falls in 2025. They show that Africa's challenge is not a shortage of ideas or innovation, but the difficulty of turning knowledge into action across institutions, sectors, and communities. The paper highlights how closer collaboration, ethical governance and locally grounded innovation can help build a more inclusive and resilient future for the continent.



Key messages



Africa is rich in ideas, creativity, and innovation. The enduring challenge lies not in imagination, but in translating promising concepts into solutions that deliver sustained, everyday impact for people and communities.



Across the continent, many good ideas stall at the level of pilots, projects or policy documents. This is not due to a lack of ambition, but to weak, fragmented, or underdeveloped systems that struggle to support scale, continuity and long-term value creation.



Economic growth alone is insufficient. When innovation is pursued without deliberate inclusion, it risks deepening existing inequalities, leaving rural communities, women, and young people at the margins rather than enabling them to participate meaningfully in development.



Persistent infrastructure gaps continue to constrain progress. Unreliable electricity, limited digital access, and weak connectivity quietly undermine advances in agriculture, education, finance, and climate resilience, even where new technologies are technically available.



Solutions that succeed elsewhere cannot simply be transplanted. Development strategies are most effective when they are rooted in local knowledge, cultural contexts and lived realities, rather than imported wholesale from external models.



Technology can be a powerful enabler, but only when guided by clear rules and shared values. Innovations such as fintech, smart cities, and digital platforms deliver benefits when they are governed in ways that are ethical, accountable, and aligned with social goals.



Africa's future depends on collaboration rather than silos. Sustainable progress emerges when researchers, policymakers, businesses, and communities work together to turn knowledge into practical solutions that improve lives on the ground.



Introduction

For decades, Africa's academic, industrial, and commercial systems have operated largely in isolation. Universities have produced knowledge, industry has pursued innovation, and markets have driven growth, but with limited integration between them. This separation has contributed to fragmented development outcomes, including technologies that fail to gain local adoption, industrial initiatives that overlook environmental sustainability, and education systems that remain weakly aligned with labour market needs. Knowledge without application risks irrelevance, while markets without research-informed guidance risk short-termism and instability. These structural gaps provided the impetus for the Atlas Global Academic Conference.

The Atlas Global Academic Conference in Victoria Falls, Zimbabwe, in August 2025 marked the launch of a long-term platform designed to bridge these divides. Conceived as more than a conventional academic event, the conference connects theory and practice, universities and markets, and Africa and its global diaspora. Its objective is to foster dialogue that translates research into inclusive growth-growth that strengthens rural economies, empowers marginalised groups and enables African societies to participate in the global knowledge economy on equitable and self-defined terms.

A core output of each Atlas Global Academic Conference is a flagship publication that consolidates and extends the ideas generated through the event. The Victoria Falls conference gives rise to an edited volume published by Emerald (UK), *The Handbook of Innovation and Inclusive Growth in Africa*, scheduled for release in early 2026. This ensures that conference deliberations are embedded within wider scholarly, policy, and practitioner debates, in a way that extends impact beyond the conference itself.

The Atlas platform is structured as a rotational forum hosted across strategically significant African locations. This design reflects the recognition that inclusive growth cannot be centralised in a single geography, but must be cultivated across diverse institutional, economic, and cultural contexts.

Following its inauguration in Victoria Falls, the conference will convene in Cape Town and subsequently in Zanzibar, Mauritius, Egypt, Kenya, Ghana, Nigeria, and other locations. Thereby, grounding its agenda in the continent's varied development realities.

Discussions in Victoria Falls underscored that Atlas is not a one-off event, but the foundation of a transdisciplinary movement. While deliberations highlighted persistent structural tensions, they also revealed substantial opportunity for collaboration and innovation. The Atlas initiative seeks to convert this potential into action by creating sustained spaces for co-creation among scholars, policymakers and industry leaders by aligning knowledge production with Africa's long-term development priorities.

“Inclusive growth in Africa remains constrained by weak integration between universities, industry and markets, which limits the translation of research into scalable impact.”

Agriculture, Food Security And Energy Resilience

Agriculture remains foundational to livelihoods, employment, food security, and climate resilience across Africa. Digital agriculture, climate-smart farming practices, and market transformation initiatives are increasingly recognised as critical levers for improving productivity, managing climate risk, and strengthening food systems. However, realising this potential requires addressing persistent structural and infrastructural constraints that continue to limit scale and impact.

Evidence presented at the conference highlighted a clear tension between innovation potential and on-the-ground realities. While digital tools such as precision farming platforms, AI-enabled crop planning, and data-driven market access systems offer pathways to greater efficiency and resilience, their adoption remains uneven. In many contexts, unreliable energy supply, weak digital connectivity and limited institutional capacity undermine implementation. For example, ongoing electricity load-shedding in South Africa was cited as a significant barrier, in disrupting agri-processing and reducing the productivity gains promised by digitalisation.

Frugal innovation models in micro-farming, agrotourism marketing, and low-cost digital advisory services illustrate how African entrepreneurs and communities are adapting technologies to local constraints. However, these initiatives often struggle to move beyond pilot stages due to fragmented financing, weak agricultural extension services, and insufficient coordination between policy frameworks. As a result, innovation ecosystems remain fragile and highly dependent on external support.

A more coordinated and strategic approach across key areas is required to translate agricultural innovation into sustained food and energy resilience. This includes strengthening rural energy infrastructure, aligning digital agriculture initiatives with national food security strategies, improving access to finance for smallholders and reinforcing institutions that support knowledge transfer and market integration. Without this enabling architecture, the promise of digital and climate-smart agriculture will remain constrained, and productivity gains will continue to fall short of their potential.



“While agriculture remains central to livelihoods, employment, and food security across Africa, significant efforts targeting both production and support systems are required to translate innovation into sustained resilience”

Smart Cities, Smart Villages and the Ethics of Technology

Africa's growing interest in smart cities and smart villages reflects a broader ambition to harness digital technologies to accelerate development, improve service delivery, and enhance urban and rural resilience. When effectively deployed, data-driven systems and smart governance tools can support more efficient cities and better access to services. However, significant efforts may be required to ensure that technological innovation builds trust and delivers inclusive outcomes rather than reinforcing existing inequalities.

Evidence presented at the conference highlighted key barriers that continue to constrain the impact of smart initiatives. Chief among these are weak governance frameworks, uneven digital infrastructure, and limited institutional capacity to manage complex socio-technical systems.

Research on smart city governance in African contexts cautions against techno-deterministic approaches that prioritise technological rollout over social and ethical considerations. Without contextualisation and human-centred design, smart city projects risk benefiting narrow elites while marginalising informal settlements, rural communities, and vulnerable groups.

Smartness without inclusivity was repeatedly identified as a major risk. Policy analyses on the deployment of digital technologies in African cities show that, even as new digital services emerge, they can intensify spatial and social divides between urban and rural areas, formal and informal economies, and connected and disconnected populations. These risks are amplified where data governance, accountability mechanisms, and citizen participation remain weak.

Within the conference's 'smart villages' track, contributors emphasised the dangers of applying urban-centric smart city models to rural settings without adaptation. Instead, participants argued for locally grounded approaches that privilege community agency and locally relevant design. Aligning technology deployment with local needs and values was seen as essential to building trust and ensuring that digital innovation contributes meaningfully to rural development.

The discussions underscored that unlocking the developmental potential of smart cities and villages requires a coordinated and strategic focus on governance, infrastructure, and ethics. Without such an enabling architecture, the promise of smart technologies risks remaining fragmented and socially contested rather than serving as a foundation for inclusive and sustainable growth.

“While smart cities and smart villages offer Africa a significant opportunity to accelerate development and improve service delivery, substantial efforts are required to ensure that digital innovation builds trust and delivers inclusive outcomes.”



The Future of Work, Education and Artificial Intelligence

The acceleration of artificial intelligence, alongside automation, remote work and the growth of green economies, is reshaping labour markets across Africa and creating new opportunities for economic diversification. AI-enabled systems have the potential to augment skills, improve job matching and support emerging sectors such as renewable energy, agri-tech, and digital services. However, realising these benefits will require significant efforts to address structural barriers that heighten risk and limit the readiness of education and training systems.

Evidence presented at the conference highlighted a widening gap between the pace of technological change and the capacity of education systems to respond. While technical and vocational education and training (TVET) was identified as a critical pathway for supporting AI-enabled and green industries, curricula remain poorly aligned with industry needs, particularly in data literacy and applied problem-solving. At the same time, firms often invest minimally in long-term skills development, and rely instead on short-term labour strategies. Fragmented digital infrastructure and uneven access to AI tools further compound these challenges, thereby reinforcing existing inequalities in skills acquisition.

Gendered and generational dynamics were repeatedly emphasised as central concerns. Without deliberate strategies to ensure that women and young people can access AI-related skills and employment pathways, the expansion of AI risks reproducing entrenched labour market hierarchies in new digital forms rather than enabling upward mobility.

A coordinated and strategic approach across education, labour market policy, and technology governance is therefore required.

This includes aligning TVET and higher education curricula with AI and green economy demands, strengthening digital and energy infrastructure, incentivising employer investment in workforce development, and embedding inclusion and ethical considerations within AI adoption strategies. Without such an enabling architecture, AI-driven transformation of work risks deepening exclusion rather than supporting inclusive and sustainable employment growth.

“Without a coordinated and inclusive approach to AI adoption, skills development and labour market governance, the future of work risks reproducing existing inequalities rather than enabling broad-based and sustainable employment.”

Fintech, Financial Inclusion and Regulation

Africa's growing fintech ecosystem presents a significant opportunity to deepen financial inclusion, improve access to credit, and support small and medium-sized enterprises and underserved populations. Bank-fintech partnerships, mobile money platforms, and evolving cryptocurrency frameworks in countries such as Zimbabwe illustrate how digital finance can extend services beyond traditional banking systems. When effectively governed, fintech has the potential to reduce transaction costs, expand access to financial services, and contribute to more inclusive economic growth.

However, conference discussions highlighted that realising these benefits requires substantial efforts to address regulatory, infrastructural, and market risks that continue to constrain the sector. Participants raised concerns about anti-competitive practices, market concentration, and the exclusion of SMEs and informal enterprises from emerging digital finance ecosystems.

Weak or uneven regulatory frameworks, limited supervisory capacity, and gaps in digital infrastructure heighten these risks and can undermine trust in fintech systems.

Empirical evidence presented at the conference reinforced this tension. While studies show that fintech adoption can improve financial inclusion and reduce income inequality in African economies, these outcomes are contingent on the presence of enabling regulation, reliable infrastructure, and effective consumer protection.

In the absence of such safeguards, rapid fintech expansion risks amplifying financial exclusion, exposing users to fraud and instability, and entrenching dominant market players.

A coordinated and strategic approach to fintech governance is therefore essential. This includes strengthening regulatory capacity, investing in digital and financial infrastructure, and aligning innovation with broader financial inclusion objectives. Without such an enabling architecture, fintech's transformative potential risks being realised only in narrow segments of the economy rather than serving as a foundation for inclusive and sustainable financial systems.

“Significant efforts to align fintech innovation with effective regulation and infrastructure may be required to build trust and reduce barriers that exclude small firms and underserved populations from the benefits of digital finance.”

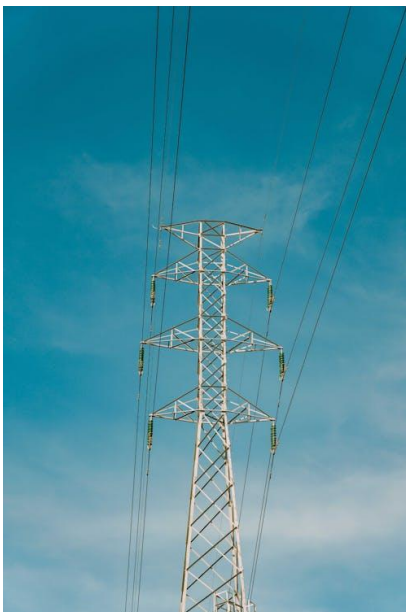


Exhibit 1. Africa can leverage institutional trust to reduce risk and unlock inclusive growth



Case study: Trust and institutional capacity in Nigeria

Nigeria is Africa's largest economy and most populous country, with a diverse private sector, deep entrepreneurial base, and strategic importance within regional and global markets. The country's growth potential covers energy, finance, digital services, manufacturing, and agribusiness, supported by a large domestic market and strong informal enterprise activity. However, despite sustained economic dynamism, Nigeria continues to face persistent constraints linked to weak institutional trust and uneven governance capacity, which shape how markets function and how economic actors manage risk.

In practice, inconsistent regulatory enforcement, policy reversals and perceptions of limited accountability have elevated transaction costs and uncertainty for firms and investors. As a result, businesses frequently rely on personalised, relationship-based trust networks to secure contracts, access finance, and navigate regulatory processes. While these informal mechanisms enable coordination and short-term resilience, they also restrict scalability, exclude new entrants, and undermine the development of transparent and competitive markets. Evidence from Nigeria's export-oriented SMEs and financial sector illustrates how trust deficits in formal institutions discourage long-term investment and favour short planning horizons.

Addressing these constraints requires a coordinated strategy focused on strengthening institutional credibility and system-level trust. Priority measures include improving regulatory consistency, enhancing enforcement capacity and increasing transparency in public decision-making. Complementary investments in digital governance systems and dispute resolution mechanisms can further reduce uncertainty and reliance on informal arrangements. Strengthening institutional trust is therefore central to lowering market risk, broadening participation and enabling more sustainable economic growth in Nigeria.

Indigenous Knowledge, Language and Cultural Integrity

Africa's rich indigenous knowledge systems and linguistic diversity represent a significant but underutilised asset for inclusive development and the ethical deployment of digital technologies, including artificial intelligence. When appropriately integrated, indigenous knowledge and local languages can enhance the relevance and adoption of innovation across sectors. However, realising this potential requires deliberate efforts to address structural and cultural risks that threaten the integrity and sustainability of these knowledge systems.

Discussions at the conference highlighted a central tension between global connectivity and local relevance. As Africa's digital transformation accelerates, there is a risk that innovation models imported from external contexts may marginalise vernacular knowledge, weaken linguistic diversity, and erode cultural heritage. AI-driven research and digital platforms that fail to account for local languages and epistemologies can inadvertently exclude communities and reproduce existing power asymmetries in knowledge production and access.



Evidence from educational and digital inclusion panels underscored that innovation is most effective when it is co-created rather than transferred. Participants emphasised that community agency, cultural context, and linguistic inclusion are critical to building trust and ensuring meaningful uptake of new technologies. Without these foundations, digital and AI-driven initiatives risk remaining extractive, externally oriented, and misaligned with local development priorities.

A coordinated and strategic approach is therefore required to embed indigenous knowledge, language, and cultural integrity within Africa's innovation ecosystems. This includes supporting multilingual digital infrastructure, investing in AI models that reflect local languages and contexts and strengthening participatory governance in innovation design. Without such an enabling framework, the benefits of digital transformation risk being uneven and culturally dislocating rather than inclusive and locally grounded.

“While Africa's indigenous knowledge systems and linguistic diversity offer significant opportunities to strengthen inclusive and ethical innovation, substantial efforts are required to ensure that digital transformation does not marginalise local languages or erode cultural integrity.”

Celebrating Transdisciplinary Engagement

Transdisciplinary engagement emerged as a defining strength of the Atlas Global Academic Conference and a critical enabler of effective problem-solving in complex development contexts. Rather than treating disciplines as isolated silos, the conference framed transdisciplinarity as a mode of co-creation that integrates academic expertise with policy insight, private sector experience, and community knowledge. This approach reflects a growing recognition that Africa's development challenges require integrated responses that cut across technical, social, economic, and institutional domains.

Conference sessions demonstrated the practical value of this approach in action. Agricultural scientists engaged with social scientists to examine how innovation interacts with local institutions and livelihoods; fintech entrepreneurs exchanged perspectives with policymakers on balancing experimentation and regulation; and educators worked alongside conservationists to address the social and ecological dimensions of sustainability. These interactions generated solutions grounded in lived realities and institutional constraints rather than abstract or discipline-bound models.

Discussions consistently underscored that Africa's most pressing challenges are inherently systemic. Climate adaptation cannot be addressed through environmental science alone without consideration of governance, finance, and social inclusion. Food security cannot be secured through agronomy in isolation from energy systems, markets, and cultural contexts. Digital inclusion similarly depends on ethical, linguistic, and political dimensions alongside technological capability. Transdisciplinary engagement therefore functions as a practical response to complexity rather than an academic aspiration.

The conference positioned transdisciplinarity as essential to producing credible, scalable and context-sensitive solutions. Strengthening such engagement is central to aligning research and innovation with real-world conditions and supporting inclusive and sustainable development outcomes across Africa.

“No single discipline can address Africa's development challenges; integrated, transdisciplinary approaches are essential”.



Future Pathways: Towards Inclusive Growth

Achieving inclusive growth in Africa will require a shift from fragmented initiatives towards institutionalised, long-term collaboration across research, policy and markets. Conference discussions underscored the need to anchor the Atlas platform as a durable mechanism for coordination rather than a stand-alone annual event.

Institutional arrangements such as joint research and policy hubs, structured industry–academia pipelines, and inclusive innovation platforms were identified as necessary to convert knowledge exchange into scalable development outcomes.

Infrastructure constraints emerged as a binding limitation on future growth pathways. Persistent energy insecurity, digital connectivity gaps, and weak rural–urban integration continue to raise costs, constrain productivity, and undermine the resilience of innovation ecosystems.

Investments in reliable power systems, digital backbone infrastructure, and integrated transport and logistics networks were consistently identified as preconditions for inclusive growth.

Without addressing these structural bottlenecks, gains from digitalisation, green transition, and technological innovation are likely to remain uneven and fragile.

“Africa’s future growth pathways require institutionalised collaboration, resilient infrastructure, and effective governance of digital transformation to translate

As digital transformation accelerates, governance and ethics were identified as central to sustaining inclusion and trust. Future growth pathways require regulatory frameworks that embed ethical oversight, competition safeguards, and protection of digital rights.

Evidence from smart cities and digital finance discussions, demonstrates that weak governance can lead to market concentration, exclusion and declining public confidence. Strengthening institutional capacity to govern emerging technologies is therefore critical to ensuring that innovation supports equity rather than exacerbating disparities.

The role of Africa’s global diaspora was framed as a strategic asset in future growth trajectories. Diaspora networks can mobilise skills, capital, and international partnerships, by reinforcing linkages between local innovation ecosystems and global markets. Systematically integrating diaspora engagement into development and innovation strategies was identified as a means of enhancing knowledge transfer, investment flows, and policy credibility.

Inclusive growth depends on the development of knowledge economies that expand opportunity and productivity across the population. This requires targeted investment in education and skills, digital literacy, recognition of indigenous knowledge systems, and the scaling of locally grounded innovation.

Future pathways that align institutions, infrastructure, governance, and human capital will be essential to translating Africa’s growth potential into sustained and inclusive development outcomes.



Conclusion and Questions

Africa's pursuit of inclusive growth can be advanced by strengthening collaborative platforms that connect knowledge, policy and markets, and by embedding innovation within resilient institutions and infrastructure. The Atlas Global Academic Conference 2025 demonstrated that inclusive development will not emerge from isolated initiatives, but from coordinated efforts among academia, industry, policymakers, and communities across the continent and globally. Moving from strategy to action will require sustained partnerships capable of translating ideas into scalable outcomes.

For example, collaboration can help reduce fragmentation across innovation ecosystems, align research with real-world challenges, and accelerate delivery through shared capabilities. Partnerships can also strengthen infrastructure planning, embed trust in digital transformation, and ensure that indigenous knowledge and local context inform innovation.

In addition, coordinated engagement across regions enables cross-border learning, reinforces regional integration, and supports the diffusion of solutions that are locally grounded yet globally connected.

Through its rotational hosting model, the Atlas platform can deepen continental ownership and ensure that inclusive growth is envisioned and enacted across Africa's diverse contexts. Institutionalising the platform beyond an annual convening can help convert dialogue into action through joint research programmes, innovation partnerships and policy engagement mechanisms. Such an approach can contribute to building knowledge economies that empower youth, women, and marginalised groups, while supporting resilient and sustainable development.

Sustaining progress will require consistent joint action and mutual accountability across public and private actors. The following questions will help frame how the Atlas platform and its partners can support the next phase of Africa's inclusive growth agenda:

1. How can collaborative platforms such as Atlas be institutionalised to move from dialogue to delivery at scale?
2. What partnership models are most effective in aligning academia, industry, and policymakers around inclusive growth objectives?
3. Which infrastructure investments are most critical to reducing risk and supporting inclusive innovation across regions?
4. How can digital transformation be governed to embed ethics, trust, and accountability while sustaining innovation?
5. How can indigenous knowledge, language, and local context be systematically integrated into development and innovation strategies?
6. What role can Africa's global diaspora play in mobilising skills, investment, and cross-border learning?
7. What accountability frameworks are needed to ensure collaborative initiatives deliver inclusive and sustainable outcomes?



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